Identifying main ideas in readings

Practical guide for students | D04-ST

Focus on what the writer is saying about the topic and how the details support it. Understanding the main idea does not always require understanding every word.

1. Check your reading purpose

Read any questions or instructions before you begin. Are you reading for an overview, looking for particular information or examining an argument closely?

Use that purpose to decide which sections need your attention.

2. Preview the text

Look at the title, headings, introduction, conclusion and any figures or tables. Predict the topic and how the text is organised.

Treat this as a starting point—you may need to revise your prediction as you read.

3. Identify what each section says

For each paragraph or short section, ask:

- What is the topic?
- What is the writer saying about it?
- Which sentence or sentences best express that point?

The main idea may appear near the beginning, later in the section or across several sentences. Do not assume the first sentence always contains it.

4. Separate the main idea from supporting details

Notice how examples, figures, explanations and evidence support the writer's point.

Ask: "What are these details helping to explain or demonstrate?"

If an unfamiliar word prevents you from understanding the main point, check it. Otherwise, mark it and continue reading.

5. Write a short summary

Express the main idea in your own words. Keep the central meaning and leave out details that are unnecessary for your reading purpose.

You can make initial notes in a language that helps you think, while following any language requirements for submitted work.

6. Check your interpretation against the text

Identify the sentences that support your summary. Check that you have preserved important contrasts, conditions and qualifications.

If you compare summaries with a classmate, discuss the evidence for each interpretation. Return to the text to resolve differences.

7. Example

Text

"A café's sales revenue increased by 10% in June. However, its ingredient and staffing costs increased by 18%. As a result, its profit fell despite the rise in revenue."

Possible summary	Check against the text
The café's business improved because revenue increased.	Overlooks the fall in profit.
Staffing costs were the café's only problem.	Adds a claim the text does not make.
The café's profit fell because costs increased more than revenue.	Captures the main relationship explained in the text.

8. Check your understanding

- I know why I am reading.
- I can explain the main point of the relevant section.
- I can distinguish the main idea from supporting details.
- My summary preserves the writer's meaning.
- I can identify text that supports my interpretation.

If you still need help: show your teacher the passage and your attempted summary. Ask a focused question, such as: "I think the main point is …, because these sentences say …. What have I missed?"

9. Supporting sources

RMIT University. (n.d.). Active reading. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports identifying a reading purpose and choosing an appropriate reading approach. See "Getting started with active reading".

University of Cincinnati, Learning Commons. (n.d.). Reading for main ideas vs. details. Open resource

Supports previewing text, distinguishing main ideas from details and identifying evidence. See "Reading for Main Ideas" and "Reading with a Purpose".

RMIT University. (n.d.). Summarising. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports preserving meaning and qualifications and checking summaries against the original. See "How to write a summary".